



AI SEO Mastery Pro [Start ...

0%

Getting Started



SEO Foundation



Setting Up Your AI



Local SEO Foundations



How to Do Local AI SEO



The Google Business Pr...



Creating AI Content



Building a Core 30 Web...



Starting Off-Site AI SEO



Introduction to Backlinking

External Anchor Text Guideli...

Local Authority Building

Searching for Link Opportun...

Monthly Google News Featu...

Blog Commenting

Social Signals

Optimizing for AI Syste...



How ChatGPT Makes Reco...

External Anchor Text Guidelines



1.2x

2 min 59 sec ⚡ 2 min 29 sec

When building backlinks to your website, the anchor text you use plays a critical role in how search engines perceive those links. Unlike internal anchor text, external anchor text requires a more diverse and natural approach to avoid triggering spam signals

The most important principle for external anchor text is to make your link profile look organic and natural. Professional SEO work should be invisible – your links should appear as if they were earned naturally through great content and genuine recommendations.

Key Guidelines to Follow

Avoid Repetition

Never use the same anchor text repeatedly across multiple external links. Repetitive anchor text is one of the strongest spam signals to search engines. The only exception is for exact match keywords, which you might repeat once or twice – but only when you have 20-40+ total backlinks to dilute the pattern.

Natural Keyword Integration

When incorporating keywords into your anchor text:

[How to Check Business Visi...](#)[Proving Business Legitimacy](#)[High Quality Mentions](#)[Create Even More Schema](#)[Review Diversification and S...](#)[Reddit Optimization](#)

Special Circumstances

[YMYL-Niche Sites](#)[Ethics: E-E-A-T Authorship ...](#)[When to Use a Sitemap](#)[NoFollow Attributes on Links](#)[Hiding Content from Users](#)[Disavowing Existing Backlin...](#)

Non-Local SEO

[Non-Local SEO Engagement...](#)[Basic Site Structure](#)[Search Console for Existing ...](#)[Click Through Rate \(CTR\) A...](#)[Identify Content with Existin...](#)[Generate Topical Relevance](#)[Keyword Research Philosop...](#)[AI-Generate Keyword Variati...](#)

destination page's topic

- Match the anchor text meaning to the destination URL's content

 **Remember:** Google analyzes the content surrounding your link, not just the anchor text itself. Context matters!

Strategic Placement

Always place external links within the main body content of the page. Avoid:

- Footer links
- Sidebar links
- Links within heading tags

Body content links carry the most weight and appear most natural to search engines.

External Anchor Text Formula

The optimal distribution for a natural backlink profile

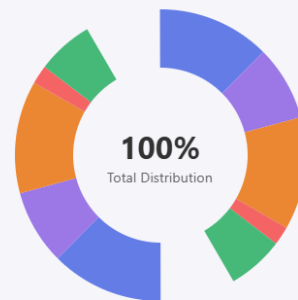
30% Branded Anchor Text
Use your business name or brand variations
Examples: "YourBusiness", "YourBusiness.com"

30% Keyword-Rich Partial Match
Target keywords with additional words
Examples: "best plumber in Dallas area", "affordable Dallas plumbing services"

5% Exact Match
Your exact target keyword (use sparingly!)
Examples: "plumber Dallas", "Dallas dentist"

20% Generic Anchor Text
Common call-to-action phrases
Examples: "click here", "read more", "visit site"

15% Natural Variations
Synonyms and related terms
Examples: "attorney" instead of "lawyer", "dental office" instead of "dentist"



The 30-20-30-5-15 Formula

For a natural-looking external link profile, follow this distribution:

30% Branded Anchor Text



20% Generic Anchor Text

Include phrases like "click here," "read more," or "visit this site." While we avoid these for internal links, they're essential for external link diversity.

30% Keyword-Rich Partial Match

Add extra words to your target keywords to create longer, more natural phrases. For example, if targeting "plumber Dallas," use "experienced plumber in Dallas area" or "Dallas plumber services near me."

5% Exact Match

Use your exact target keyword sparingly. This is your most powerful but also most dangerous anchor text type. Limit to 2-3 instances maximum, even with many backlinks.

15% Natural Variations

Use synonyms and related terms without the exact keyword. For instance, use "attorney" instead of "lawyer" or "dental practice" instead of "dentist."

 **Warning:** Over-optimization of external anchor text is one of the fastest ways to trigger a Google penalty. When in doubt, err on the side of being too natural rather than too optimized.

Comparing Internal vs. External Anchor Text

Key Differences from Internal Linking:

- Internal links should avoid generic text; external links need it
- Internal links can be more keyword-focused; external links require more variety
- Internal links shouldn't use naked URLs; external links benefit from them



▶▶ For a refresher on internal linking strategies, review the [Internal Anchor Text Guidelines](#) lesson in the *Creating AI Content* module.

These percentages serve as guidelines, not rigid rules. Your primary focus should always be creating a link profile that appears natural and provides value to users across the web.